

BERGEN NORWAY



“Buried” Salmon in Bergen

When the rays are glittering across Bergen harbor on a sunny summer day, the fish market, or *fisketorget*, seems literally to sparkle as visitors and locals gather to shop, browse, and eat. The hub of this bustling port city for several hundred years, this famous market is full of stands heaped high with delights of the sea and that Scandinavian favorite, deep-hued gravadlax.



Bergen’s history stretches back as far as the 11th century, and in its heyday it was a headquarters for the Hanseatic League – northern Europe’s dominating trade alliance in the late

Middle Ages. The league was made up of German and Scandinavian seafaring merchants, and the legacy of the German merchants can still be experienced in the oldest, most charming of the city’s neighborhoods, known as Bryggen. A UNESCO World Heritage site since 1979, the 62 gently leaning wooden merchants’ houses here have been lovingly restored to their former glory, and wandering among these rickety antique houses is like entering a wooden maze. Several have been opened up as museums, while others sell typical Norwegian handicrafts, from fluffy knitwear to ornate Sami reindeer-bone knives.

Fish has always played a vital role in Bergen – it was responsible for drawing the Hanseatic League to the town’s shores in the 13th century, at around the same time that one of Norway’s national dishes *par excellence*, gravadlax, appeared on the culinary scene.

This signature dish, today most often served as an appetizer, was invented by fishermen, who would salt and then bury their freshly caught salmon, leaving it to ferment in the sand at high tide. “*Grav*” literally means “grave,” and “burying” the salmon gave it a very distinctive flavor. These days you won’t see any Norwegians digging up their dish of the day from the beaches, but gravadlax remains just as tasty, having been “buried” and cured in a marinade of salt, sugar, dill, and often a dash of aquavit or gin.

Much has changed in Bergen since the fish-trading of the Middle Ages, but the scene at the fish market is every bit as lively, as gregarious sellers vie for customers against the backdrop of the Hanseatic houses. Stands are piled high with bright orange or pink gravadlax, smoked salmon, rosy shrimp, purple lobsters, red crayfish, and apricot-colored mussels. Open sandwiches stacked with fish and seafood call out to be eaten from improvised cafés with rustic wooden benches. It’s not hard to imagine a merchant in the Middle Ages tucking into the same dishes on the same spot some 600 years ago.

Food with a View

Bergen is surrounded by *de syv fjell* (“the seven peaks”), mountains with stunning views of Bergen and the nearby islands and fjords. Several offer foodie experiences with a view. **Fløien Folkerestaurant** (www.bellevue-restaurant.no), one of the Historic Restaurants of Norway, is reached by the Fløibanen Funicular Railway, one of Bergen’s main sights. Its old, atmospheric building is open daily in summer for traditional Norwegian cooking. Mount Ulriken, reached by bus and gondola from central Bergen, has the city’s highest restaurant, **Sky:skraperen** (www.ulriken643.no). It serves gravadlax and other traditional dishes. **Jacob Aall Bar & Brasserie** (www.jacobaall.no) offers good views without the need to climb a peak first. Located on top of a tall downtown building, you can admire the views from the bar on the premises.



Above Gravadlax with fresh dill and black peppercorns

The Best Places to Eat Gravadlax

Enhjørningen Fish Restaurant expensive

Enhjørningen Fish Restaurant, Bergen’s oldest fish restaurant, is steeped in the city’s history, housed as it is in an old Hanseatic wharf house in the Bryggen quarter near the harbor. Parts of the building date from the 14th century and the enchanting decor gives you the feeling of having stepped into the living room of an old merchant’s house, complete with antique furniture and paintings.

The menu ranges from the traditional to the more adventurous, with an emphasis on fresh local fish and seafood. Top choice must be their gravadlax, which is cured in aquavit – a caraway-flavored schnapps – and served with mustard sauce. For those with a hearty appetite, there are plenty of other unusual dishes to sample, including *rakørret* (cured trout – another traditional Norwegian dish) and vendace roe, a specialty. The three-course tasting menus, one of which includes the gravadlax dish, are particularly good buys.

Enhjørningsgården 29, Bergen; open 4–11 PM daily, closed Sun Sep–mid-May; www.enhjoeringen.no

Also in Bergen

To taste some exquisite homemade gravadlax, try newly opened **Cornelia Seafood Restaurant** (+47 55 011 885; *moderate*), somewhat ironically located in the old meat market area. Alf Roald Sætre and Odd Einar Tufteland, the men behind the establishment, really know their seafood. In 2004 they opened one of the city’s most popular seafood and fish restaurants, **Cornelius Restaurant** (www.cornelius-restaurant.no; *moderate*), reached only by boat from central Bergen. Both restaurants are worth a visit for the sheer variety of fresh fish and seafood they offer; they also have no less than five different recipes for home-cured gravadlax, which is available to buy in the fishmonger’s next door to the Cornelia Restaurant.

Also in Norway

In Stavanger, **Sjøhuset Skagen** (www.sjohusetskagen.no; *expensive*), housed in an old, bright-red-painted timbered building, serves home-cured gravadlax with the traditional accompaniments of salad, mustard dressing, and dark rye bread.

Around the World

The Smörgås Chef (www.smorgas.com; *inexpensive*) has no less than three prime locations across New York, offering the very best of Scandinavian cuisine, including their own home-cured gravadlax. A special treat is their aquavit-cured salmon with traditional cucumber-dill salad and mustard sauce.